SALESFORCE ADMIN COURSE • EPISODE 38

Restriction Rules & Scoping Rules

Advanced Data Filtering in Salesforce: Restricting Access Beyond OWD, Focus-Driven Scoping, Architecture Comparisons, and Hands-on Testing on Custom Objects.

- 🔒 Restriction Rules = Hard Security Filtering
- 🎯 Scoping Rules = Focus & Noise Reduction (UX)
- ⚖️ Sharing vs. Restriction vs. Scoping Triad
- 🛡️ Impact on Search, Lookups, Reports & SOQL
- ⚡ Admin Bypass Permissions (View All Data / Records)
- 🪄 Practical Implementation with Employee__c

Created by Sachin • Salesforce Certified Administrator Series • Duration: ~20–25 Mins

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1. Introduction: The Need for Inward Record Filtering

In the previous episode on **Record-Level Security**, we learned the classic outbound rule of Salesforce sharing:

> *"OWD establishes the most restrictive baseline. Role Hierarchy, Sharing Rules, and Manual Sharing can ONLY open access further."*

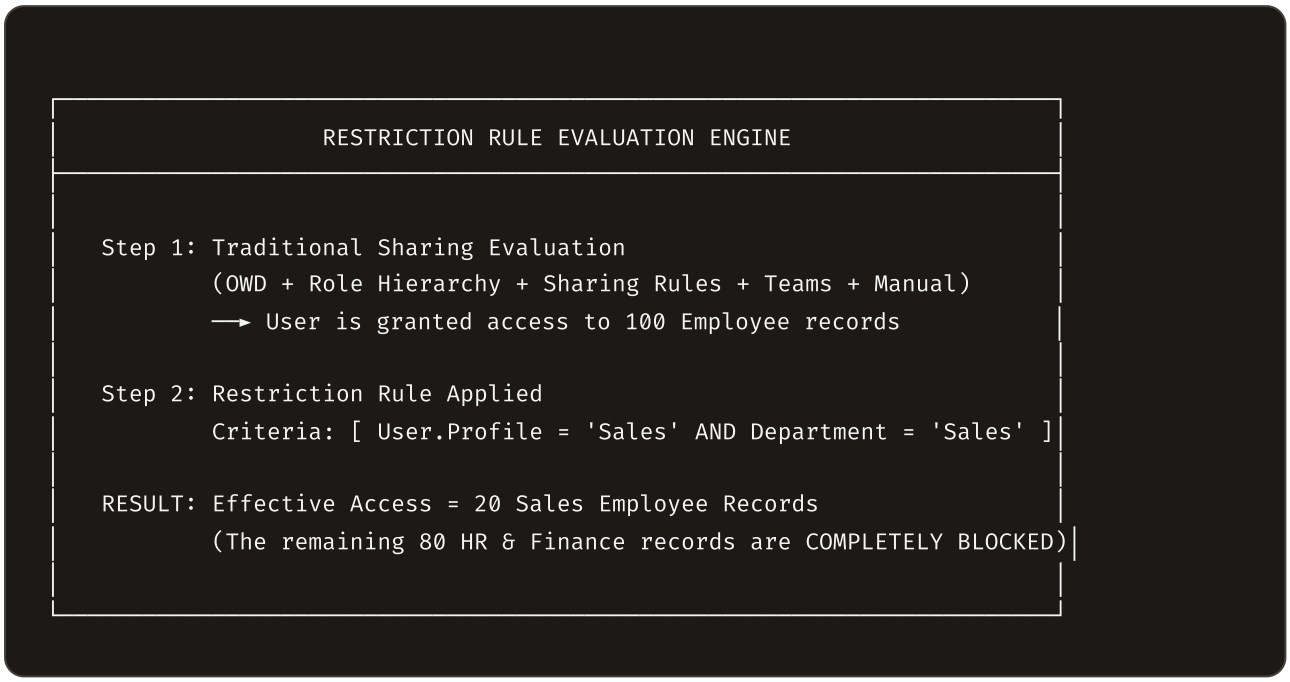
For years, that was an absolute rule. Sharing could only **give** access; it could never **take it away**. But this created major challenges for modern enterprises:

- *"What if users have broad access via OWD or sharing, but compliance demands that Sales Reps only see employees or contracts from their own department?"*
- *"What if a user has access to 50,000 records, but gets overwhelmed by noise and needs a default view focused on their active operational records without revoking access?"*

To address these two distinct needs, Salesforce introduced **Restriction Rules** and **Scoping Rules**.

2. What is a Restriction Rule?

A **Restriction Rule** prevents a user from accessing records that would otherwise be shared with them. It further filters the accessible records down to **only those matching specified record criteria**.



Salesforce officially describes Restriction Rules as a security control where a user who has access to an object can only view the records that meet the specified rule criteria.

3. How Restriction Rules Work

A Restriction Rule consists of two main criteria:

1. User Criteria

Defines **WHO** the rule applies to. Configured using User fields, Profiles, Roles, or Permissions (e.g., `$User.Department = 'Sales'` or `$User.Profile.Name = 'Sales User'`).

2. Record Criteria

Defines **WHICH RECORDS** matching users are allowed to access (e.g., `Department__c = 'Sales'` or `IsConfidential__c = false`).

Global Platform Enforcement:
Unlike UI filters, a Restriction Rule applies across the **entire platform**: List Views, Global Search, Lookups, Reports & Dashboards, and direct **SOQL queries via the API**!

4. When to Use Restriction Rules & Bypass Permissions

Restriction Rules are specifically recommended for:

- **Regulatory & Sensitive Compliance:** Preventing users from seeing records outside their designated business unit or country.
- **Confidential Tasks & Events:** Hiding internal executive meetings, sensitive HR tasks, or legal contracts from general staff.
- **Custom Object Isolation:** Enforcing strict departmental boundaries on objects like `Employee__c`, `Timesheet__c`, or `Salary_Review__c`.

Who Bypasses Restriction Rules?

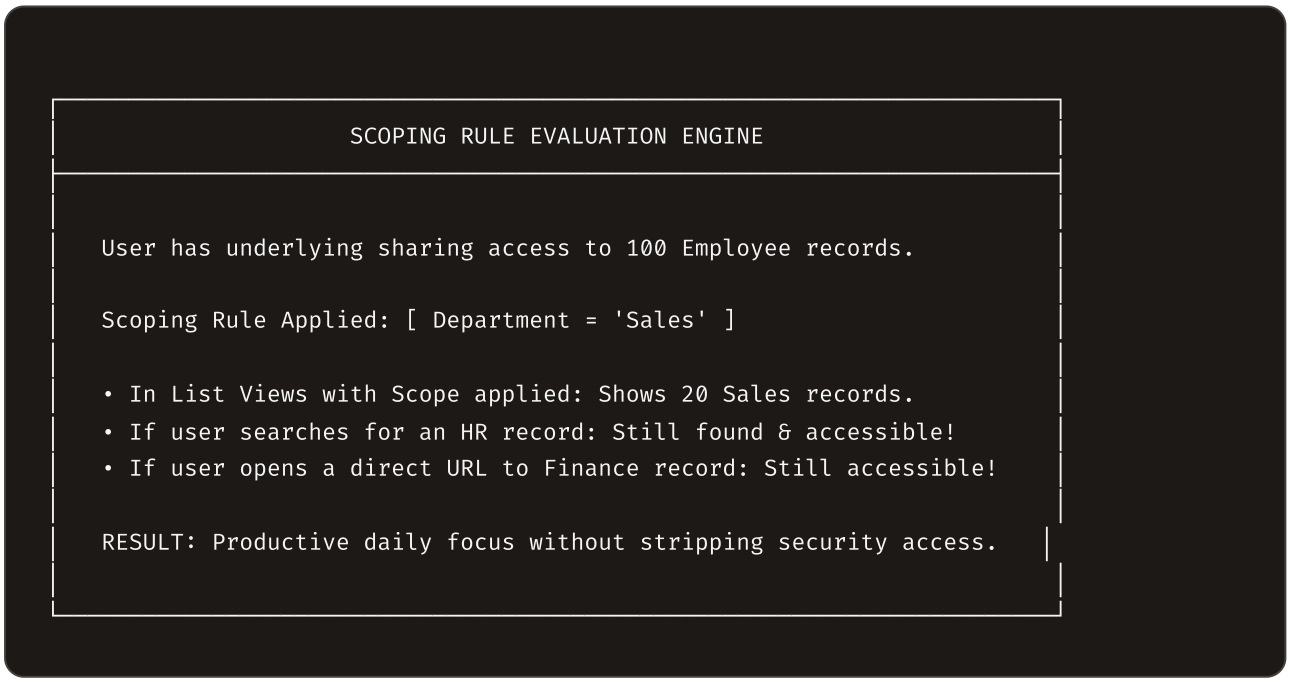
Users possessing high-level system permissions are exempt from Restriction Rules to ensure proper administrative control and system integration:

- View All Records / Modify All Records on that specific object
- View All Data (VAD) / Modify All Data (MAD) system permissions

5. What is a Scoping Rule?

A **Scoping Rule** lets you control the default records that users see when looking at List Views, Reports, and SOQL queries, **WITHOUT restricting their underlying access**.

> **The Core Philosophy of Scoping Rules: Focus & Noise Reduction**
> A user might legitimately need access to all 10,000 customer accounts across the enterprise, but on a daily basis, they only care about accounts in their region. Scoping Rules help them focus on their relevant slice of data without locking them out if they need to look up a cross-regional record!



6. The Core Difference: Security vs. Focus

FEATURE	RESTRICTION RULE	SCOPING RULE
Primary Purpose	Hard Security & Access Lockdown	User Focus & Productivity
Underlying Record Access	**Actually Removed / Restricted**	**Untouched & Preserved**
What happens on direct URL?	"Insufficient Privileges" Error	Record opens successfully
What happens in Global Search?	Unmatched records NEVER appear	Unmatched records CAN be found
Where is it applied?	Search, Lookups, Views, Reports, SOQL	List Views, Reports, and SOQL (`USING SCOPE`)

7. Practical Demo Part 1: Configuring a Restriction Rule

We will demonstrate this using our custom object `Employee__c` with four test records:

- **Rahul** (Department = *Sales*)
- **Neha** (Department = *Sales*)
- **Priya** (Department = *HR*)
- **Amit** (Department = *Finance*)

STEP 01 — **Navigate to Restriction Rules in Object Manager**

```
Setup ➔ Object Manager ➔ Employee ➔ Restriction Rules ➔ New Rule
```

Enter Rule Name: `Sales_Employees_Only`. Ensure **Is Active** is checked.

STEP 02 **Configure User Criteria & Record Criteria**

```
Restriction Rule Definition Modal
```

- **User Criteria:** *Which users does this rule apply to?*
  Select: `$User.Department EQUALS 'Sales'` (or Profile = `Sales User`).
- **Record Criteria:** *To which records do the specified users have access?*
  Select: `Department__c EQUALS 'Sales'`.

Click **Save**.

STEP 03 **Test the Restriction Rule as Sales User**

```
Log in as Rahul (Sales User) ➔ Open Employee Tab
```

1. Open the "All Employees" list view ➔ Only **Rahul** and **Neha** appear.
2. Type "Priya" into Global Search ➔ No records found.
3. Paste the direct URL of Priya's HR record ➔ Insufficient Privileges error!

The restriction rule has strictly locked down data access at the security layer.

8. Practical Demo Part 2: Configuring a Scoping Rule

STEP 04 **Create a Scoping Rule on Employee__c**

```
Setup ➔ Object Manager ➔ Employee ➔ Scoping Rules ➔ New Rule
```

(First deactivate the previous Restriction Rule to test scoping independently).
Enter Rule Name: `Sales_Employee_Scope`. Check **Is Active**.

- **User Criteria:** `$User.Department EQUALS 'Sales'`
- **Record Criteria:** `Department__c EQUALS 'Sales'`

Click **Save**.

STEP 05

Test the Scoping Rule in Action

```
Log in as Rahul ➔ Employee List View
```

1. Select the scoped filter view ➔ Rahul sees **only Sales employees** (Rahul and Neha).
2. Now search for **Priya** in Global Search ➔ Priya's record appears!
3. Open Priya's HR record ➔ Record opens normally!

The Scoping Rule helped Rahul focus without revoking his underlying sharing rights.

9. The Ultimate Triad Comparison

Remember this fundamental formula whenever analyzing Salesforce record architecture:

🤝 SHARING RULE

GIVES

Expands record access beyond OWD baseline based on owner or criteria.

🔒 RESTRICTION RULE

RESTRICTS

Filters out records a user already has access to; strictly blocks visibility.

🎯 SCOPING RULE

FOCUSES

Filters default views/reports to reduce clutter without altering permissions.

EVALUATION FEATURE	SHARING RULES	RESTRICTION RULES	SCOPING RULES
Primary Action	Grant / Open Access	Restrict / Remove Access	Filter / Focus Display
Changes Access Level?	Yes (Broadens)	Yes (Constricts)	No (Preserved)
Can make access more restrictive?	No	Yes	No
Criteria-based?	Yes (Owner or Field)	Yes (User & Record)	Yes (User & Record)
Bypassed by View All Data?	N/A (additive)	Yes	Yes
Best Used For	Cross-team collaboration	Strict departmental isolation	Productivity & daily relevance

10. Key Takeaways & Architectural Summary

1. Restriction Rules are Real Security

They operate as a negative filter over normal sharing. If a record doesn't meet the rule's record criteria, the user cannot see it in search, reports, lookups, or APIs.

2. Scoping Rules are Productivity Tools

They guide users to relevant records in supported views and reports without stripping their ability to view other records when needed.

3. The 3-Word Mental Model

Sharing Rule = GIVE.
Restriction Rule = RESTRICT.
Scoping Rule = FOCUS.

4. Admin Superpowers Bypass Rules

Users with *View All Records*, *Modify All Records*, *View All Data*, or *Modify All Data* bypass restriction rules entirely.

11. Next Episode Preview

📺 Coming Up in Episode 39: Security Audit, Login Forensics & Access Troubleshooting

Now that we have covered every single layer of Salesforce security (Org-Level, Object-Level, Field-Level, Record-Level, and Restriction Rules), how do administrators troubleshoot real-world access issues? In Episode 39, we will master the **Sharing Hierarchy Button**, **Setup Audit Trail**, **Login Forensics**, and **Health Check** to audit and secure any Salesforce environment!